

# Edinburgh, City of Literature - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

## The First City of Literature

In two thousand and four, Edinburgh was named the first UNESCO City of Literature in the world. Not the first in Britain, the first anywhere, the founding member of a club that now stretches from Dublin to Melbourne to Baghdad. The idea itself was hatched here, and then handed to the world. Stop and think how strange that is. Scotland is a small country, barely five million people, roughly the population of a mid-sized city, and yet an astonishing share of the books the whole world grew up on were dreamed up within a short walk of where you are standing.

Consider the roll call. The man who invented the historical novel. The man who wrote *Treasure Island* and gave every later pirate his parrot and his map. The city where detective fiction was essentially born, in Sherlock Holmes. The cafes where a struggling single mother wrote a boy wizard. Add Burns, Scotland's national poet, whose songs you have sung without knowing it, and Muriel Spark, and a whole shelf of modern crime, and you have a few square miles that have printed more of what the world reads than almost anywhere on earth.

Why here? Part of the answer is machinery. By the seventeen hundreds Edinburgh was one of Europe's great centres of printing and ideas, the engine room of the Scottish Enlightenment. The very first Encyclopaedia Britannica was published right here, in seventeen sixty-eight. Presses, publishers, booksellers and arguing philosophers were packed into these closes cheek by jowl, and books poured out of them.

And part of the answer is the city itself. Edinburgh is a place of two faces. The cramped, dark, medieval Old Town of winding closes and towering tenements, and across the valley the calm, orderly, elegant Georgian New Town. A city literally split in two, respectable and rational on one side, tangled and shadowy on the other. That double nature seeped into its writers, and you will hear it echo again and again in the stories that follow. Halfway down the Royal Mile, tucked into Lady Stair's Close, a small free museum honours three of them. Let us meet them, one by one.

## Robert Burns, Scotland's Voice

Start with a test. Have you ever, at midnight on New Year's Eve, crossed your arms, joined hands with strangers and sung a song about old acquaintance being forgot, without having the faintest idea what the words mean? Then you have sung Robert Burns. Auld Lang Syne is his, or at least his making, and it is sung every New Year in more countries than almost any song on earth. So is the line, tender and battered by a thousand greetings cards, my love is like a red, red rose. Burns is that rare thing, a poet whose words have escaped the page entirely and become something people simply do, without knowing whose they are.

He is Scotland's national poet, its Bard, and the reason is not only that he was brilliant, which he was, but that he wrote in Scots, the everyday tongue of ordinary Scottish people, at a moment when polite society was busy trying to sound properly English. Burns took the language of the farmyard and the tavern and the kitchen and made great poetry out of it, and in doing so he told Scotland that its own voice was worth hearing. He was born in seventeen fifty-nine, the son of a struggling tenant farmer in

Ayrshire, and he did much of his best work with mud on his boots.

In the winter of seventeen eighty-six he arrived in Edinburgh, twenty-seven years old, with one slim book of poems behind him, and the city lost its head over him. For a single dazzling season the ploughman poet was the toast of Edinburgh's grand drawing rooms, dined and feted by dukes and professors, and a new expanded edition of his poems was published right here in seventeen eighty-seven. It made his name across the whole country, though it never made him rich.

One of his songs you will hear echoing on another day of this trip. Burns wrote Scots Wha Hae, an imagined battle speech in the mouth of Robert the Bruce, rousing his men before they fought the English at Bannockburn. When you stand near Stirling and look out over that ground, remember that the most famous version of Bruce's speech was written not in the fourteenth century but by a farmer poet four hundred years later. That is the power of Burns. He gave Scotland the words for its own history.

Every year on the twenty-fifth of January, the day he was born, Scots the world over sit down to a Burns Supper. A haggis is carried in to the skirl of the bagpipes, someone recites Burns's mock-heroic Address to a Haggis to the steaming plate, and there are toasts and songs and rather a lot of whisky. No other poet on earth gets a global dinner party thrown in his honour every single year. Burns died young, at thirty-seven, worn out by hard living. But his voice never has.

## **Sir Walter Scott, the Wizard of the North**

Imagine a writer so famous that a great city names its main railway station after one of his novels. Not after him, after the book. When you arrive into the heart of Edinburgh by train, you step off at Waverley Station, and it is named for Waverley, the novel Walter Scott published in eighteen fourteen. It is, as far as anyone can tell, the only railway station in the world named after a work of fiction. That single odd fact tells you how enormous Scott once was.

In his own lifetime he was arguably the most famous writer alive anywhere on the planet, read hungrily from Edinburgh to Boston to Moscow. And he more or less invented something we now take for granted, the historical novel. Before Scott, novels were mostly set in the writer's own day. He had the idea of dropping invented characters into real, carefully researched history, the Jacobite risings, the Crusades, medieval England, and letting them live through great events. Waverley did it first, and it sold out in days. Then came Rob Roy, and Ivanhoe, with its jousting knights and its Robin Hood, and a whole torrent of others, written at a furious pace. They called him the Wizard of the North.

Scott did something else, too, that reaches far beyond books. He essentially designed the picture of Scotland that the world still carries in its head, all tartan and bagpipes and misty Highland romance. In eighteen twenty-two, when King George the Fourth came to Edinburgh, the first reigning monarch to visit in almost two hundred years, it was Scott who stage-managed the entire spectacle, wrapping the city and the rather plump king alike in Highland plaid. It was gloriously invented, a Lowland lawyer dressing up history, and yet it stuck so hard that we are still living inside his shortbread-tin Scotland today.

And here is a thread that ties straight back to Edinburgh Castle. A few years earlier, in eighteen eighteen, Scotland's ancient crown jewels, the Honours of Scotland, the oldest crown jewels in the British Isles, had been missing for more than a century, locked away and forgotten after the union with England. It was Walter Scott who got royal permission to hunt for them, and it was Scott who stood there when a sealed chamber in the castle was broken open and the crown, sword and sceptre were found inside, exactly where they had been abandoned. If you saw them glinting behind glass at the castle today, you have Scott the storyteller to thank. He treated his country's history as a treasure worth digging for, and in that case quite literally.

You cannot miss his memorial. On Princes Street, right beside the station that bears his book's name, stands the Scott Monument, a soaring, blackened Gothic spire more than sixty metres high, with Scott

carved in white marble beneath it and his beloved dog at his feet. It is often called the largest monument to a writer anywhere in the world. Opinions on his novels have cooled over two centuries, and some find them heavy going now. But no writer ever shaped a nation's image of itself more completely, and no city ever said thank you in taller stone.

## **Robert Louis Stevenson and the City's Double Life**

Robert Louis Stevenson gave the world two things that have never left it. One is the pirate. *Treasure Island*, published in eighteen eighty-three, is the source code for almost every pirate story you have ever seen. The buried gold and the map marked with a cross, the one-legged rogue with a parrot on his shoulder, the black spot, the sea chest, the rum, all of it flows from this one Edinburgh writer's imagination. Before Stevenson, pirates were mostly grubby criminals. After him, they were adventure. He followed it with *Kidnapped*, a breathless chase across the Scottish Highlands, and cemented himself as one of the great storytellers in the English language.

But his deepest and strangest book grew directly out of the city you are standing in. In eighteen eighty-six Stevenson published *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*, the story of a respectable doctor who brews a potion that lets him transform into a monstrous second self, Mr Hyde, so that he can do in the dark what he would never dare do in daylight, and who slowly loses control of which man he is. It has become one of those rare stories whose very title turned into everyday language. When we call someone a Jekyll and Hyde, everyone understands.

Now, where would a boy get such an idea? Look around you. Stevenson was born here in eighteen fifty, and he grew up in a city with two faces. There was the elegant, buttoned-up, respectable New Town, where his own comfortable family lived, and there was the tangle of dark Old Town closes just a short walk away, full of drink and poverty and secrets, where a respectable gentleman might slip off at night to misbehave. Stevenson, a sickly, restless young man, knew both sides intimately. The whole city was a Jekyll and Hyde before he ever wrote the words.

And there was a particular ghost at his shoulder. Edinburgh had a genuine local legend of a double life, a man named Deacon William Brodie. By day Brodie was the very model of respectability, a skilled cabinetmaker, a member of the town council, a pillar of the community. By night he was a burglar, using his good name and his knowledge of people's locks to rob the very houses he was welcomed into. When he was finally caught and hanged in seventeen eighty-eight, the story went that he was executed on a gallows he himself had helped to improve, though historians think that final twist is more legend than fact. Here is the eerie part. The Stevenson family owned a cabinet made by Brodie's own hands, and it stood in young Robert's bedroom. He grew up sleeping beside furniture built by Edinburgh's most famous respectable criminal. Years later, that childhood image of a man with two selves, one shown to the world and one hidden, poured out as Jekyll and Hyde.

Stevenson never really thrived in Scotland's cold, wet air. His weak lungs eventually drove him to the far side of the world, and he died in eighteen ninety-four on a tropical island in Samoa, only forty-four years old, mourned by the islanders who had come to love him. But the two things he gave the world, the pirate and the divided soul, were both born here, in a city of two faces.

## **Sherlock Holmes Was Born in a Classroom Here**

The greatest detective in the history of fiction was, in a sense, born in an Edinburgh medical school. Arthur Conan Doyle, the man who created Sherlock Holmes, was born in this city in eighteen fifty-nine, and he trained here as a doctor. And the famous method that makes Holmes who he is, that trick of looking at a total stranger and reading their whole life from tiny clues, Conan Doyle did not invent. He watched a real man do it, right in front of him, in a lecture theatre at the University of Edinburgh.

That man was Doctor Joseph Bell, a brilliant surgeon and teacher, and Conan Doyle was his student and later his clerk. Bell had a party piece that astonished everyone who saw it. A stranger would walk into the room, a patient he had never met, and before the person had said a word about their illness, Bell would tell them their trade, where they had recently travelled, what they had done that morning, all from the smallest of details. The callus on a hand, the mud on a boot, a line of sunburn, a way of standing, a scrap of an accent. To onlookers it seemed like magic. Bell insisted it was nothing of the kind. It was simply observation, close and trained, of things sitting there in plain sight for anyone who bothered to look.

Conan Doyle never forgot it. When he sat down years later to write a detective story, he built his hero around exactly that method. Sherlock Holmes greets Doctor Watson at their very first meeting by deducing, correctly and instantly, that Watson has just come back from military service in Afghanistan, and the reader is hooked for the next hundred and thirty years. Holmes first appeared in eighteen eighty-seven, in a story called *A Study in Scarlet*, and went on to become perhaps the most famous fictional character on earth, with his deerstalker hat and his pipe. Conan Doyle later wrote to Bell and told him plainly, it is most certainly to you that I owe Sherlock Holmes.

What is easy to miss is how genuinely new this was. Before Holmes, mystery stories tended to solve themselves through luck, or confession, or coincidence. Conan Doyle gave the world a hero who solved crimes by reason, by evidence, by paying attention, treating a crime scene the way Bell treated a patient. In doing so he did not merely write some popular stories, he essentially built the modern detective story, the whole vast genre of crime fiction and courtroom drama and forensic television that we swim in today. Real detectives began studying his methods, and some early forensic scientists cited Holmes as an inspiration.

So the next time you watch a detective on television dazzle everyone by noticing the one tiny thing nobody else saw, remember where the trick was learned. In an Edinburgh hospital, from a real doctor with a genius for looking, watched by a medical student who was quietly taking notes that would change storytelling forever.

## **Modern Edinburgh, From Miss Brodie to a Boy Wizard**

Edinburgh did not stop making world famous books when the Victorians packed up. If anything the last seventy years have been another golden run. Take Muriel Spark, one of the sharpest writers of the twentieth century, whose most famous novel, *The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie*, appeared in nineteen sixty-one. It is the story of a charismatic, dangerous Edinburgh schoolteacher who picks a favoured set of pupils and tries to mould their lives, and it is set in exactly this kind of Edinburgh, all propriety on the surface and something more complicated underneath. If that theme is starting to sound familiar, you have been paying attention.

Then there is the crime. Edinburgh has produced a whole school of dark, brilliant crime writing that Scots half-jokingly call *Tartan Noir*. Its king is Ian Rankin, whose detective, Inspector John Rebus, has prowled the real pubs and back streets of this city through more than twenty novels. Rankin uses the crime story the way Stevenson used the ghost story, to peel back the respectable face of Edinburgh and show you what lies underneath. Read him and you will never quite see the city's tidy Georgian streets the same way again. Fiercer still is Irvine Welsh, whose novel *Trainspotting*, published in nineteen ninety-three, told the raw story of a group of young heroin addicts in the Leith district of the city, in the real, blunt, unpolished speech of its streets. It became a defining book, and then a famous film, of its generation. It is emphatically not a children's story, but it is proof that this city's writers still write with total honesty about the life around them.

And then, of course, there is the wizard. In the nineteen nineties a young single mother named Joanne Rowling, short of money and writing partly to keep warm, drafted much of the early Harry Potter in Edinburgh cafes, filling notebooks over a single slowly cooling coffee while her baby slept beside her. That

much is true and well documented. Around it, though, the city has grown a happy tangle of fan legend, and it is worth knowing which is which. Fans love to point to one particular cafe as the birthplace of the books, though Rowling actually wrote in several places, and did a good deal of her work in a cafe owned by her brother-in-law. Fans also love to wander Greyfriars Kirkyard, the old graveyard nearby, and find a weathered headstone bearing the name Thomas Riddell, delighting that Lord Voldemort's real name is Tom Riddle. And they gaze up at George Heriot's School, a beautiful old turreted school beside the graveyard, and see in it the towers and houses of Hogwarts. These links are lovely, and the walk is a delight, but they are fan theories, not confirmed by Rowling herself, so enjoy them with a pinch of salt.

What all these writers share, across three hundred years, is that they keep finding their stories in this same small, steep, double-faced city. Miss Brodie's classroom, Rebus's pubs, and Harry's cafes are all a few minutes' walk from where Burns was feted and Stevenson was born. Some cities inspire one great book. Edinburgh keeps doing it, century after century.